A Relational Framework of the Self

Lived Identity, Self-Image, Shadow, Reflection, and Integration

A conceptual psychological model of self-construction, interpersonal mirrors, and growth

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Conceptual paper

Abstract

The psychological self is neither a single representation nor a fixed inner essence. Human beings simultaneously enact patterns of behaviour, construct beliefs about who they are, imagine who they would like to become, selectively present themselves to others, and infer how others perceive them. These representations may correspond closely, but they may also diverge. This paper proposes an integrative framework for understanding these relations.

The model distinguishes six components: the **Lived Self**, or relatively stable patterns expressed through behaviour, emotion, motivation, valuation, and choice; the **Self-Image**, the person's internal model of who they believe themselves to be; the **Integrated Self**, consisting of self-relevant characteristics that are consciously recognized and representable; the **Shadow Self**, consisting of self-relevant tendencies that remain denied, poorly represented, or insufficiently integrated; the **Ideal Self**, representing valued possible ways of being; and the **Projected Self**, representing the socially expressed or strategically presented version of the person. A second part of the framework describes interpersonal perception as a potential mirror. It distinguishes **integrated recognition**, **shadow projection**, **aspirational reflection**, and **external perception**, thereby avoiding the unfalsifiable assumption that every judgment of another person is a projection of oneself.

The framework further distinguishes an observer's belief about how another person sees them - the **reflected image** - from the other person's actual appraisal. A **composite observer** is introduced as a methodological ideal in which self-report, behaviour, lived experience, and multiple external perspectives are triangulated rather than allowing any single perspective to define identity. Psychological development is described through two complementary processes: **integration**, in which already-existing but insufficiently represented aspects of the person become consciously recognized, and **development**, in which desired characteristics become increasingly instantiated through action. The central regulatory principle is **sincerity**, understood not as indiscriminate acceptance of every self-judgment or external criticism, but as willingness to revise one's self-model when sufficiently reliable evidence warrants revision.

The resulting framework treats selfhood as a dynamic process of model construction, interpersonal reflection, error correction, and intentional development.

Keywords: self-concept; self-knowledge; reflected appraisal; self-discrepancy; projection; shadow; identity; ideal self; interpersonal perception; psychological integration

1 Introduction

Human beings live from at least two positions simultaneously. They *are* something, in the sense that they repeatedly behave, feel, value, desire, avoid, decide, and relate in characteristic ways. But they also *represent themselves to themselves*.

A person can behave courageously while believing themselves cowardly. They can describe themselves as patient while repeatedly becoming hostile under frustration. They can possess an ability that they barely recognize, or maintain a flattering identity that is poorly supported by their actions.

The distinction between lived experience and self-representation has a long history in psychology. Rogers emphasized congruence and incongruence between experience and self-concept [8, 9]. Higgins later formalized discrepancies among actual, ideal, and ought self-representations and connected different discrepancies to characteristic emotional vulnerabilities [4]. Research on self-concept clarity, reflected appraisal, and self-knowledge likewise suggests that self-representation is structured, socially influenced, and fallible [2, 10, 7].

This paper develops these themes into a broader relational model of selfhood. The central claim is not that there exists a perfectly observable, metaphysically fixed "true self." Rather, psychological identity can be studied as a relationship among:

1. patterns a person actually instantiates;
2. the representation they maintain of themselves;
3. characteristics they consciously acknowledge;
4. characteristics that remain insufficiently acknowledged;
5. characteristics they aspire to develop;
6. the version of themselves they present socially; and
7. information about themselves made available through other people.

The framework therefore treats the self as a **dynamic model under continual revision**.

2 The Architecture of the Self

2.1 The Lived Self

The first component is the **Lived Self**. In earlier formulations of the framework this was described as the "true" or "actual" self. For theoretical precision, *Lived Self* is preferable because it avoids implying a hidden metaphysical essence.

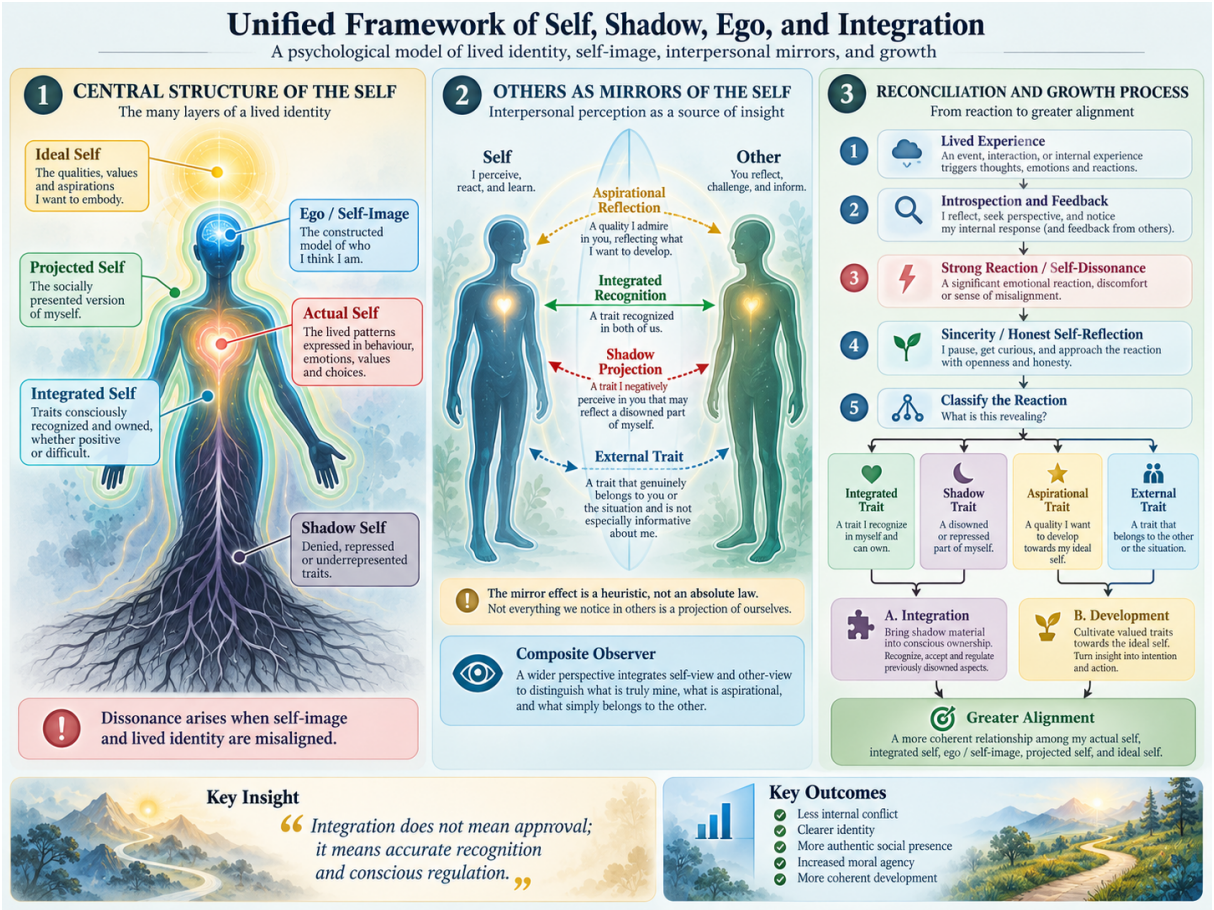


Figure 1: Unified overview of the proposed framework. The diagram organizes the architecture of the self, interpersonal mirror mechanisms, and the processes of reconciliation, integration, and development.

The Lived Self refers to the best available estimate of patterns that the person actually instantiates across experience. These include recurring patterns of behaviour, emotional response, motivation, valuation, interpersonal conduct, attention, desire, avoidance, decision-making, and adaptation to circumstances.

We may represent the lived tendency of person p, regarding characteristic x, across contexts c and time t, as

$$L_p(x) = F(B_{p,c,t}, E_{p,c,t}, M_{p,c,t}, V_{p,c,t}, \dots), \tag{1}$$

where B represents behaviour, E emotion, M motivation, and V valuation.

Importantly, $L_p(x)$ is not directly observable as a perfect quantity. It is inferred. A broad trait such as generosity cannot be established from a single generous act, just as one late arrival cannot establish that someone is globally unconscientious. The Lived Self is therefore **evidence-constrained but fallible**.

It answers the question:

> *What patterns does this person actually tend to instantiate?*

2.2 The Self-Image or Ego

Humans do not continuously recompute their identity from raw experience. They maintain an internal model. We call this model the **Self-Image**, or, in the broader language of the framework, the **Ego**.

Let

$$E_p(x) \tag{2}$$

represent person p's belief that characteristic x describes them.

The Self-Image contains propositions such as "I am independent," "I am compassionate," or "I am bad at conflict." It also contains broader personal narratives: "I am the kind of person who helps others," "people never understand me," or "I need to remain strong."

The Ego is therefore not synonymous with selfishness, arrogance, or narcissism. It is a **self-model**. Such a model is psychologically useful: it provides continuity across time, supports planning, constrains expectations, organizes autobiographical memory, and helps regulate social interaction.

Problems emerge when the model becomes resistant to correction. A well-calibrated self-model behaves approximately like a revisable hypothesis:

$$E_{t+1} = U(E_t, \text{new evidence}), \tag{3}$$

where U represents updating. A rigid ego instead tends toward

$$E_{t+1} \approx E_t \tag{4}$$

even when contradictory evidence accumulates. Experience is then increasingly interpreted in ways that preserve identity rather than revise it.

3 Self-Dissonance

The distinction between Lived Self and Self-Image produces the first important quantity in the framework:

$$D(x) = d\big(L(x), E(x)\big), \tag{5}$$

where D represents **self-dissonance** and d some measure of discrepancy.

The larger the mismatch between one's enacted characteristics and one's representation of them, the greater the potential for psychological conflict. This resembles, but is not identical to, self-discrepancy theory [4]. Our framework adds a prior distinction:

$$\text{lived characteristics} \neq \text{self-representation}. \tag{6}$$

Thus even a person's "actual-self representation" may itself be inaccurate.

4 The Integrated Self

Not everything psychologically unpleasant is unconscious or repressed. A person may clearly recognize characteristics they dislike about themselves. Such traits belong to the **Integrated Self**.

For example, someone may say: "I am sometimes jealous," "I become controlling when I am afraid," or "I seek approval more than I would like." These traits are available to conscious representation without requiring their exclusion from identity.

Formally, for characteristic x,

$$x \in I_p \tag{7}$$

when the person can meaningfully acknowledge x as belonging to their own psychological repertoire.

Integration does not imply frequent expression, and it does not imply moral endorsement. A

crucial proposition of the framework is therefore

$$\boxed{\text{integration} \neq \text{approval}}. \tag{8}$$

Integration means that a person can represent a possibility within themselves accurately enough to think and act upon it consciously. This is important for regulation: a tendency that cannot enter the self-model cannot easily become the object of deliberate regulation. Recognition therefore increases the possibility of agency.

5 The Shadow Self

The **Shadow Self** contains potentially self-relevant tendencies that are insufficiently represented in conscious self-understanding. In simplified notation,

$$S_p \approx L_p - I_p. \tag{9}$$

This should not be interpreted literally as set subtraction. It expresses the conceptual relationship

$$\boxed{\text{Shadow} = \text{lived structure that remains insufficiently integrated.}} \tag{10}$$

The language of the shadow is inspired by Jungian psychology [5], but the present framework uses the term more narrowly and operationally. It does not require commitment to Jung's wider theory of the psyche.

A candidate shadow characteristic requires at least some reason to believe that the characteristic is instantiated by the person, that the person's explicit self-model underrepresents it, and that psychological processes appear to inhibit its recognition.

The shadow can contain traits culturally regarded as undesirable - envy, aggression, dependency, vanity, selfishness, fear, need for attention, or desire for dominance. But it can also contain desirable or neutral qualities such as creativity, confidence, ambition, tenderness, assertiveness, sexuality, leadership, or vulnerability. The defining feature of the shadow is therefore **not negativity but non-integration**.

6 The Ideal Self

The **Ideal Self** represents characteristics the person values but does not necessarily instantiate sufficiently. Let

$$A_p(x) \tag{11}$$

describe the aspirational value assigned to characteristic x.

The Ideal Self answers the question: *Who would I like to become?*

It may contain qualities such as courage, patience, discipline, compassion, wisdom, independence, creativity, or emotional stability.

The distinction between Lived Self and Ideal Self is fundamental. If courage is aspirational but not yet reliably enacted, then

$$A(\text{courage}) \gg L(\text{courage}) \tag{12}$$

may accurately describe the person's state.

The psychological problem appears when the Ego prematurely absorbs the Ideal Self:

$$A(x) \to E(x) \tag{13}$$

without corresponding behavioural evidence. The aspiration "I want to become courageous" then becomes the identity claim "I am courageous." The Ideal Self therefore serves development best when it remains a **direction**, rather than being mistaken for an accomplishment.

7 The Projected Self

The **Projected Self** is the version of the self made available to other people. Let

$$P_{p \to q} \tag{14}$$

represent the presentation of person p to observer q.

This presentation is selective. Different relationships reveal different aspects of a person, and social environments place different demands on expression. The Projected Self is therefore not necessarily deceptive.

Difficulties arise when the social image becomes increasingly disconnected from lived identity:

$$d(P, L) \uparrow . \tag{15}$$

At the extreme, preserving the appearance of being a particular kind of person can become more important than actually becoming that person. The individual begins maintaining a character.

8 How the Self-Image Is Constructed

The Self-Image does not originate from introspection alone. It is composed from several information channels. A simplified model is

$$E_t = U(E_{t-1}, X_t, M_t, F_t, R_t, A_t, N_t, B_t), \tag{16}$$

where:

- X_t: current experience;
- M_t: autobiographical memory;
- F_t: direct feedback;
- R_t: reflected appraisal;
- A_t: aspirations;
- N_t: social and cultural norms;
- B_t: motivational and cognitive biases.

This construction explains why self-images may deviate from lived structure. Memory is selective. Feedback may be incomplete. Social norms influence what is acceptable to identify with. Aspirations may become confused with present characteristics. Threat may encourage defensive processing. Beliefs already present in E_t influence which new evidence is noticed and how it is interpreted.

Self-image is therefore simultaneously **informative and constructed**.

9 Other People as Mirrors

Humans learn about themselves socially. The idea that the self develops partly through perceived evaluations by others has a long intellectual history in the "looking-glass self" and later work on reflected appraisal [3, 10, 7]. The metaphor of another person as a **mirror** is therefore psychologically useful.

Taken literally, however, it becomes misleading. The statement "everything I notice in you is really about me" is untenable. The framework instead proposes four possible relations.

9.1 Integrated Recognition

Suppose person A notices characteristic x in person B. If A already consciously recognizes x in themselves, then the recognition is approximately symmetric:

$$x \in I_A \quad \text{and} \quad x \in B. \tag{17}$$

For example: "They are highly competitive. I am too." No projection hypothesis is required. This is **Integrated Recognition**.

9.2 Shadow Projection

A second case occurs when a trait perceived in another person corresponds to something poorly integrated in oneself. This becomes a candidate **Shadow Projection**:

$$x \in L_A, \qquad x \notin I_A, \qquad x \text{ strongly salient in } B. \tag{18}$$

Classical projection has received some empirical support, although modern reviews suggest that projection is more complicated than the simplest psychoanalytic interpretation [1]. Accordingly, this framework does not infer shadow from criticism alone. The reaction generates a hypothesis: *Why is this characteristic particularly salient or emotionally charged for me?*

9.3 Aspirational Reflection

A positive reaction may operate differently. Suppose someone strongly admires another person's independence, wisdom, confidence, creativity, calmness, or courage. The admired characteristic may correspond to the observer's Ideal Self:

$$A_A(x) \text{ high} \tag{19}$$

while

$$L_A(x) \text{ lower.} \tag{20}$$

The other person functions not as a reflection of what has been rejected, but of **what could be developed**. This is **Aspirational Reflection**. Admiration becomes information about direction.

9.4 External Perception

Finally,

$$x(B) \tag{21}$$

may simply tell us something about B. Another person may genuinely be dishonest, compassion-

ate, impulsive, talented, controlling, humorous, or reckless without that fact revealing anything substantial about the observer.

This is **External Perception**. Its inclusion is essential. Without it, the mirror theory becomes circular and unfalsifiable. The framework therefore states:

$$\boxed{\text{Interpersonal perception may reveal the observer, but does not necessarily do so.}} \tag{22}$$

10 Emotional Intensity as a Clue, Not Proof

One potentially useful indicator is **disproportionate affective salience**. If two people display comparable behaviour but one produces an unusually intense reaction, there may be something psychologically informative about that interaction.

Let

$$Q_A(B, x) \tag{23}$$

represent the emotional intensity generated in observer A by characteristic x in B.

High Q increases the usefulness of asking whether x interacts with the observer's own self-structure. But

$$Q \text{ high} \not\Rightarrow \text{projection.} \tag{24}$$

A strong reaction can result from trauma, moral commitments, past relationships, immediate threat, incompatible goals, genuine mistreatment, shadow dynamics, envy, aspiration, or many other causes. Emotional intensity is therefore an **investigative signal**, not a diagnosis.

11 The Reflected Image

The mirror process contains another distinction that is easily overlooked. Suppose person A asks: "What does B think of me?" There are actually two different objects.

The first is

$$J_B(A), \tag{25}$$

the appraisal that B actually holds of A.

The second is

$$R_{A\leftarrow B}(A), \tag{26}$$

the appraisal that A **believes** B **holds of** A.

These need not be equal:

$$R_{A\leftarrow B}(A) \neq J_B(A). \tag{27}$$

The second is what this framework calls the **Reflected Image**. Research on reflected appraisal and meta-perception suggests that people's estimates of how others see them are partly shaped by their own existing self-views [10, 7].

Thus the reflected image is itself a construction. The interpersonal mirror is not a perfect optical mirror. It is more like

$$\text{Other} \rightarrow \text{social cues} \rightarrow \text{interpretation} \rightarrow \text{reflected image}. \tag{28}$$

12 Self-Image and Reflected Image

We can now distinguish two central representations:

$$E_A(A) \quad \text{“How I see myself.”} \tag{29}$$
$$R_{A\leftarrow B}(A) \quad \text{“How I believe you see me.”} \tag{30}$$

The discrepancy between them can itself become psychologically meaningful:

$$D_R = d\left(E_A(A), R_{A\leftarrow B}(A)\right). \tag{31}$$

Someone may believe “I am considerate” while simultaneously thinking “this person sees me as selfish.” That discrepancy may produce defensiveness, curiosity, shame, dismissal, or self-revision. Whether revision is appropriate depends on the quality of the evidence.

13 The Composite Observer

No single observer has privileged access to the whole person. Self-report has unique access to internal states but suffers from bias and blind spots. Other people can observe behaviour unavailable to introspection but cannot directly access all motives, feelings, or intentions. Single behavioural events are context-dependent, and individual informants carry their own distortions.

The framework therefore introduces a methodological ideal called the **Composite Observer**. Rather than asking "Who is right?", it asks: *What structure survives comparison across perspectives?*

For person A, the evidence might include

$$\mathcal{C}_A = \{E_A(A), J_{B_1}(A), J_{B_2}(A), \ldots, B_A, X_A\}, \tag{32}$$

where $E_A(A)$ is self-appraisal, $J_{B_i}(A)$ are independent informant appraisals, B_A represents behavioural evidence, and X_A represents first-person experiential evidence.

The Composite Observer does not literally exist as an omniscient mind. It is a **triangulation procedure**. The framework therefore rejects both extremes: "only I know who I am" and "other people know the real me." Instead,

$$\boxed{\text{Self-knowledge improves through appropriately weighted convergence of perspectives.}} \tag{33}$$

14 Blind Spots and the Shadow

The Composite Observer also clarifies the shadow. The Johari Window distinguishes information known and unknown to the self and to others, including a "blind" quadrant containing information visible to others but not to the person [6].

Suppose a pattern is repeatedly observed by several credible people:

$$J_{B_1}(A, x) \approx J_{B_2}(A, x) \approx J_{B_3}(A, x) \tag{34}$$

and is consistent with behavioural evidence, yet

$$E_A(A, x) \approx 0. \tag{35}$$

Then x becomes a plausible **blind or shadow candidate**. It still does not become automatically true. Informants may share cultural assumptions or interact with the person only in similar contexts. But convergence increases evidential weight.

15 Sincerity as an Updating Principle

The central regulatory mechanism of the model is **sincerity**. Sincerity is not defined here primarily as speaking honestly to others. It is an epistemic disposition toward one's own identity:

$$\boxed{\text{Sincerity} = \text{willingness to let sufficiently good evidence revise the self-model.}} \tag{36}$$

This requires avoiding two opposite failures.

Defensive rigidity:

$$\text{contradictory evidence} \rightarrow \text{dismissal} \tag{37}$$

regardless of reliability.

Indiscriminate suggestibility:

$$\text{external judgment} \rightarrow \text{immediate self-redefinition} \tag{38}$$

regardless of reliability.

Healthy sincerity lies between them. It asks what happened, how one behaved, whether the pattern recurs, who is giving the feedback, what context they observe, whether independent evidence converges, whether one's response is defensive, and whether both perspectives may contain partial truth.

Sincerity therefore implies **updateability, not submissiveness**.

16 Two Different Forms of Psychological Growth

The framework makes a sharp distinction between **integration** and **development**. They solve different problems.

16.1 Integration

Integration concerns what is already substantially present:

$$S \rightarrow I. \tag{39}$$

A shadow characteristic becomes representable within the conscious self-model. The progression can be written as

$$\text{unrecognized} \rightarrow \text{noticed} \rightarrow \text{acknowledged} \rightarrow \text{contextualized} \rightarrow \text{regulated}. \tag{40}$$

The question of integration is: *What am I already, including what I would rather not be?*

16.2 Development

Development concerns what the person values but does not yet reliably instantiate:

$$A \to L. \tag{41}$$

The person converts aspiration into behaviour:

$$\text{value} \to \text{intention} \to \text{practice} \to \text{behaviour} \to \text{habit or capacity}. \tag{42}$$

Development asks: *What do I want to become?*

17 Why the Distinction Matters

These two processes are easily confused. A person may attempt to become their ideal self while continuously rejecting their lived self. They may cultivate kindness while refusing to acknowledge anger, pursue independence while denying dependency, or build confidence on top of unrecognized insecurity.

In such cases development occurs without sufficient integration. Conversely, endless examination of one's existing tendencies without meaningful aspiration can become stagnant.

The framework therefore proposes two simultaneous movements:

$$\boxed{\text{Integration} = \text{learning more accurately what I already am}} \tag{43}$$

and

$$\boxed{\text{Development} = \text{increasingly becoming what I choose to value.}} \tag{44}$$

Psychological maturity requires both.

18 Greater Alignment

The purpose of the model is not to collapse every representation into one perfectly consistent identity. That would be neither possible nor necessarily desirable. Instead, the target is **greater alignment**.

Let the principal components be

$$\mathcal{S} = \{L, I, S, E, P, A\}. \tag{45}$$

Greater psychological alignment means reducing unnecessary contradiction among the Lived Self L, Integrated Self I, Shadow Self S, Ego/Self-Image E, Projected Self P, and Ideal Self A, while preserving their legitimate differences.

The Ideal Self should exceed the present Lived Self in some respects. The Projected Self will vary by context. The Shadow may never disappear entirely. The individual will continue changing. Alignment therefore means not perfect identity among components, but **coherent relations among them**.

19 A Dynamic Cycle of Self-Formation

The complete framework can be summarized as a recurrent loop:

$$\boxed{\text{Experience} \rightarrow \text{Reaction} \rightarrow \text{Reflection} \rightarrow \text{Classification} \rightarrow \text{Integration or Development} \rightarrow \text{Updated Self-Model}} \tag{46}$$

Social interaction creates a second loop:

$$\boxed{\text{Self} \rightarrow \text{Other} \rightarrow \text{Other's response} \rightarrow \text{Reflected image} \rightarrow \text{Self-model update}} \tag{47}$$

These loops interact. The person's self-image affects how they present themselves. Their presentation affects how others respond. Other people's responses affect the reflected image. The reflected image influences the self-image. Self-appraisal and reflected appraisal are therefore mutually coupled rather than purely unidirectional.

Selfhood is consequently not simply discovered internally. It is partially **constructed relationally**.

20 Testable Propositions

Because this framework is intended as more than metaphor, its major claims should generate empirical predictions.

Proposition 1 - Self-dissonance

Larger reliable discrepancies between self-appraisal and appropriately measured behavioural or experiential criteria should predict greater psychological dissonance, particularly when the characteristic is important to identity.

Proposition 2 - Shadow candidates

When a characteristic is supported by behavioural and multi-informant evidence but strongly underrepresented in self-appraisal, it should constitute a stronger candidate for shadow status than a characteristic identified by only one observer.

Proposition 3 - Mirror salience

Emotionally intense judgments of others should contain more self-relevant information on average than emotionally neutral judgments, but the relationship should remain probabilistic rather than deterministic.

Proposition 4 - Reflected-image bias

People's beliefs about how others perceive them should partially reproduce their existing self-image rather than perfectly matching others' actual judgments.

Proposition 5 - Composite-observer advantage

For characteristics observable across contexts, properly aggregated behavioural and multi-informant evidence should produce better calibrated estimates than either isolated self-report or a single informant alone.

Proposition 6 - Integration versus development

Interventions targeting unacknowledged existing tendencies should have different psychological and behavioural effects from interventions targeting desired but weakly instantiated traits. The former should primarily alter self-representation and regulation; the latter should primarily alter behavioural capacity and habit.

21 Measurement and Empirical Development

The framework could be investigated through a combination of validated self-report inventories, behavioural observation, ecological momentary assessment, informant reports, diary studies, longitudinal designs, interpersonal interaction tasks, and repeated measures of emotional responses to others.

Each characteristic would require a domain-appropriate criterion. Emotional self-knowledge may depend heavily on first-person information, while characteristics such as punctuality or conversational dominance may be more externally observable.

A useful research design would compare four quantities:

Self-appraisal, Perceived other-appraisal, Actual other-appraisal, Behavioural/experiential criterion. (48)

Their discrepancies would allow the different mechanisms proposed here to be studied rather than inferred impressionistically.

22 Limitations

Several cautions are necessary.

First, the framework does not establish the existence of an objectively accessible "true self." The Lived Self is always an estimate constructed from imperfect evidence.

Second, the Shadow Self should not become an unfalsifiable explanation. Denying an interpretation is not proof that the interpretation is unconscious.

Third, emotional reactions to others have many possible causes. Projection represents only one.

Fourth, consensus among observers is not automatically truth. Multiple observers can share the same bias.

Fifth, complete internal consistency is neither realistic nor necessarily healthy. Humans occupy multiple social roles and can legitimately behave differently across contexts.

Finally, the framework currently remains a **conceptual synthesis**. Its distinctive propositions require direct empirical testing before it can be regarded as a validated psychological model.

23 Conclusion

The framework presented here begins from a simple distinction:

$$\text{the person} \neq \text{the person's model of the person.} \tag{49}$$

From that distinction follows a layered account of selfhood. The Lived Self represents patterns instantiated through experience. The Self-Image represents what the person believes themselves to be. The Integrated Self contains aspects they can consciously recognize. The Shadow Self contains potentially self-relevant aspects that remain insufficiently integrated. The Ideal Self represents valued possibilities. The Projected Self is the person as selectively expressed to others.

Relationships introduce another informational system. Other people can sometimes reveal what we already know about ourselves, expose possible blind spots, embody qualities we aspire toward, or simply show us something that belongs to them rather than us.

The interpersonal mirror therefore has four possible interpretations:

Integrated Recognition, Shadow Projection, Aspirational Reflection, External Perception

(50)

The image reflected through others must itself be divided into what they actually perceive and what we imagine they perceive. No single perspective is sufficient. Self-knowledge therefore emerges most reliably through a **Composite Observer**: the triangulation of subjective experience, repeated behaviour, self-reflection, interpersonal feedback, and appropriately weighted external observation.

Within this architecture, psychological growth has two complementary directions. **Integration** brings what is already present into clearer conscious representation. **Development** transforms valued possibilities into increasingly enacted capacities. Sincerity regulates both processes by allowing the internal model to change when reality provides sufficient reason for revision.

The resulting conception of selfhood is neither static nor essentialist. The self is a living relationship between experience and representation, between individual and other, and between what a person currently is and what they may intentionally become.

To know oneself is not to freeze oneself into an identity.
It is to become progressively better at seeing what is there, recognizing what is hidden, distinguishing what belongs to others, and choosing what should come next.

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